

advanced features too. One of my favourites is the 'Split' view option to divide the window into two parts—activate by F3 or *View→Split*. This option (Figure 8) comes in very handy when you want to copy/move files between two locations. Simply drag and drop the file/folder from one side to the other. By the way, the copying dialogue box has a nice notification window now, that pops out of the system tray, which even gives you the option to pause a transfer—much better than a separate floating window, I'd say. This dialogue box is not specific to Dolphin, but ubiquitous for copy/move/download/upload activities across all KDE apps.

Another good addition is the preview option in the toolbar. Now, I don't need previews for regular files, but only in a directory of images. When I go inside the images folder, I hit preview and use the zoom slider to increase the size of the thumbnails; Dolphin remembers this setting. So, next time I launch Dolphin, although the rest of the folders appear as they were, inside the Images folder, the preview option is still active, and the thumbnail sizes are still bigger. Neat, eh?

Other assorted apps

Some of the other KDE-specific tools I have to depend on heavily for my daily grind are personal information manager *Contact*, *Gwenview* image viewer and *Okular* document viewer. All of them are full-fledged apps with pretty advanced capabilities, and deserve a few pages to cover the features they each offer.

Contact is something I depend a lot on at work. Apart from the *Kmail* client and an address book, it gives me an RSS feed reader, a to-do list, a calendar, time tracker, and something called pop-up notes. I absolutely love the addition of the 'Fancy with Clickable Status' theme in *Kmail*, which finally made me switch to a vertical message preview pane using a three-column layout in

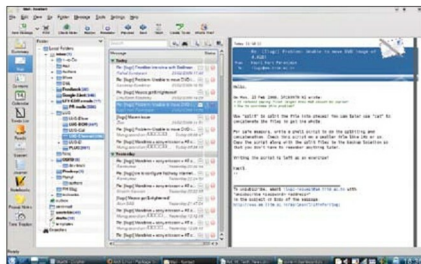


Figure 9: The 'Fancy with Clickable Status' theme in Kmail

my wide screen laptop (Figure 9).

My image viewing needs are fulfilled by *Gwenview*, which offers me some handy image editing features, apart from working as a powerful image viewer. *Okular*, on the other hand, takes care of displaying a range of document formats. For your digital camera requirements, there's *Digikam*, although the Qt4 version is still in its beta stage.

Kget is available for normal downloads. The interface is very simple to use, while it also lets me unleash a lot of advanced features when I need them. It even supports torrents and metlinks for downloads. Although, for torrents, I like sticking to *KTorrent*, which is a full blown torrent client with some fantastic features.

KDE 4.2 comes with *JuK* for an audio player and music collection manager, which does what it's supposed to do, pretty well. However, most of us are too used to *Amarok* anyway, which has also finally released its Qt4-based stable v2.0, with some intuitive features. *Dragon Player* is the default media player in the KDE4 series, which is more like its GNOME counterpart *Totem*, that does its job with no frills attached. Those who need more functionality anyway have the MPlayer-based *SMPlayer*, which I recommend

that you check out just in case you haven't already.

Besides these, there're lots of other tools in the accompanying KDE 4.2 live CD; it's just that I don't have enough space to write about them here. Explore for yourself—there are the educational tools, the highlight being the Google Earth alternative, *Marble*, and various other utility programs.

Oh wait, before I end: don't forget to check out the much-improved *System Monitor* application. The highlight of this release is the *System Load* tab. The interface has finally been made similar to its GNOME counterpart, which always had a much better UI.

Bottom line

Well, KDE 4.2 is not perfect! It still tends to crash on me occasionally for no obvious reason, but things are getting there. And even if it's still not as feature complete as KDE 3.5.10, with this release things have indeed gotten a LOT better. So, c'mon, don't be so uptight and give it a go! Or, do you really want to wait another six months for version 4.3? Well? 

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